E-Sports beyond simulation

Competing visions of Olympic inclusion and implications for Belgium and the Belgian Olympic and Interfederal Committee (BOIC)

Thomas Mavrogonatos

Final work
Belgian Olympic Academy

December 2025

Table of Contents

1. Introduction 1
   1.1. Background and context 1
   1.2. Work objectives 1
   1.3. Methodology 2
   1.4. Structure of the report 2

Part I – Understanding E-Sports and its inclusion in the Olympic movement 3

2. Defining "Sport" in the digital era 3
   2.1. Historical and theoretical perspectives on "Sport" 3
   2.2. The Olympic definition and core criteria 4
3. E-Sports and the question of legitimacy 6
   3.1. Public perception: from "Gaming" to "E-Sports" to "Sport" 6
   3.2. The professionalisation of E-Sports 8
4. The Olympic dilemma 13
   4.1. The IOC approach to E-Sports 13
5. IOC-Saudi partnership: early termination and diverging strategies 14
   5.1. Sports simulations, non-sports simulations, and the paradox of exclusion: popular games being left out 14

Part II – How should Belgium prepare itself for the future of E-Sports? 16

6. The Belgian E-Sports ecosystem 16
   6.1. Key stakeholders and institutional framework 16
   6.2. Market overview and growth trends 17
7. The "sportification" of E-Sports internationally 19
   7.1. Use Case 1 – South Korea's formal recognition of E-Sports within its Olympic movement 19
   7.2. Use Case 2 – Finland's E-Sports federation as member of the NOC 20
   7.3. Use Case 3 – E-Sports recognised as a sport in Sweden 20
   7.4. Use Case 4 – Numerous initiatives and legal recognition of E-Sports in France 21
8. Looking forward: E-Sports' inclusion within the Olympic movement 22
   8.1. The future of the Olympic E-Sports Games 22
   8.2. Embedding sports simulation titles within the scope of existing traditional sports federations 23

8.3. Conceptual: classifying sport simulation titles eligible for federation embedding 25
9. Conclusion 29
References 30
Annexes 34
Annex 1 – E-Sports vs Gaming 34
Annex 2 – Overview of the League of Legends ecosystem worldwide in 2024 35
Annex 3 – RTBF iXPé 39
Annex 4 – International Federations and E-Sports 40

List of abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning
BOIC	Belgian Olympic and Interfederal Committee
BESF	Belgian E-Sports Federation
CNOSF	French National Olympic and Sports Committee
EMEA	European, Middle East, and African
E-Sports	Electronics Sports
FPS games	First-Person Shooter games
GEF	Global E-Sports Federation
IESF	International E-Sports Federation
IF(s)	International Federation(s)
IOC	International Olympic Committee
KeSPA	Korea E-Sports Association
KOC	Korean Olympic Committee
MOBA games	Multiplayer Online Battle Arena games
NOC(s)	National Olympic Committee(s)
RTS games	Real-Time Strategy games
SEUL	Finnish E-Sports Federation
UCI	Union Cycliste Internationale
VR games	Virtual Reality games

List of Figures

Figure 1 – Pictures from the 2023 Olympic E-Sports Series (IOC, 2023) 5

Figure 2 – E-Sports audience growth since 2020 and 2025 projections (Newzoo, 2022) 6

Figure 3 – The 2024 League of Legends Worlds Final took place at the O2 Arena in London (Riot Games, 2024) 7

Figure 4 – Global E-Sports Viewership Dynamics (E-Sports Charts, 2024) 8

Figure 5 – E-Sports revenue market and 2025 – 2030 projections (Statista, 2025) 9

Figure 6 – Most watched E-Sports Games on Twitch during Q1 2025 (E-Sports Charts, 2025) 9

Figure 7 – Most watched E-Sports Games on YouTube Gaming during Q1 2025 (E-Sports Charts, 2025) 10

Figure 8 – Examples of popular French E-Sports talk shows (Zack en Roue Libre, Stonks, La Boulange, OTP LoL Gaming) 10

Figure 9 – Logos of E-Sports' two international federations (IESF & GEF) 13

Figure 10 – Popular E-Sports games in 2025 by viewership (E-Sports Charts, 2025) 15

Figure 11 – Logos of the BESF, Adeps, and Sport Vlaanderen 16

Figure 12 – Logos of the Finnish Olympic Committee and E-Sports Federation (SEUL) 20

Figure 13 – Pictures from E-Sports initiatives organised by IFs in sailing, cycling, taekwondo, and rowing 23

Figure 14 – Primary classification test criteria 26

Figure 15 – Exclusion criteria 26

Figure 16 – Governance quality check criteria 27

Figure 17 – Classification outcomes 27

Figure 18 – E-Sports vs Gaming (DifferenceBetween.Net, 2021) 34

Figure 19 – League of Legends worldwide ecosystem in 2024 (Tier 1) 35

Figure 20 – League of Legends worldwide ecosystem representation (Tier 1) 36

Figure 21 – League of Legends European, Middle-East, and African (EMEA) ecosystem (Tier 2) 37

Figure 22 – League of Legends European, Middle-East, and African (EMEA) ecosystem representation (Tier 2) 38

Figure 23 – RTBF iXPé homepage 39

Figure 24 – World Sailing announcement of 2026 eSailing World Championship 40

Figure 25 – Announcement of UCI's 2025 Cycling E-Sports World Championships 41

Figure 26 – World Rowing's partnership announceemnt with Ergatta for gaming and E-Sports development 41

Figure 27 – Virtual Taekwondo has recently been officially endorsed by World Taekwondo 42

1. Introduction

1.1. Background and context

Electronics sports (E-Sports) have evolved from niche gaming communities into a fast-growing entertainment industry in which competitive video gaming now fills stadiums, attracts sponsorships, and mobilises global audiences comparable to major traditional sports events. Games such as *League of Legends*, *Counter-Strike 2*, and *Rocket League* have moved from simple entertainment to highly structured ecosystems involving professional teams, athletes, coaches, media rights, and fan communities.

The **International Olympic Committee (IOC)**, guardian of sport's universal values, has progressively acknowledged the cultural and societal impact of E-Sports. Since 2017, the IOC has initiated exploratory steps to engage with digital sports, notably through the *Olympic Virtual Series* (2021) and the *Olympic E-Sports Week* (2023).

This evolution however also exposes tensions. The IOC's approach has, so far, limited participation to sports-simulations games (e.g. virtual cycling, tennis, archery), excluding globally dominant E-Sports that do not directly replicate physical disciplines. This selective inclusion raises fundamental questions about what constitutes a "sport" in the digital era, and who decides. The recent partnership (and early termination[1]) between the IOC and Saudi Arabia for the hosting of the ***Olympic E-Sports Games***[2] further revealed divergent visions for the future of E-Sports: one oriented toward institutional legitimacy and Olympic values, the other toward rapid commercial expansion and global influence.

In this context, Belgium stands at an interesting crossroads. The country has a growing E-Sports ecosystem supported by the Belgian E-Sports Federation (BESF), local teams and events, and in part by regional sport agencies (Sport Vlaanderen, ADEPS). Yet, as highlighted in recent analyses[3], E-Sports in Belgium remain fragmented and under-recognised, facing challenges of limited public visibility, inconsistent funding, and a lack of unified policy frameworks. As the Olympic E-Sports Games approach, **Belgium** and the **Belgian Olympic and Interfederal Committee (BOIC)** faces both an opportunity and a responsibility: to clarify its position and explore how E-Sports can be integrated into the country's sporting vision in a way that reflects Olympic values of excellence, friendship, and respect.

1.2. Work objectives

The main objectives of this work are:

---

[1] International Olympic Committee, *IOC Statement on the Olympic E-Sports Games*, 30 October 2025, accessible here.

[2] International Olympic Committee, *IOC announces Olympic E-Sports Games to be hosted in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia*, 12 July 2024, accessible here.

[3] RTBF IXPé, *Quelles perspectives d'avenir pour l'E-Sports en Belgique?*, 10 November 2025, accessible here.

1. **To explore how sport is defined in the digital era** and assess the implications of E-Sports for existing institutional frameworks of sport.
2. **To understand the evolution and legitimacy of E-Sports** as a cultural and sporting phenomenon, both globally and within Belgium.
3. **To examine the IOC's engagement with E-Sports**, including its rational for selective inclusion and the implications of its partnership decisions.
4. **To assess the Belgian E-Sports ecosystem**, including its actors, current governance challenges, perception, and potential for Olympic alignment.
5. **To study case examples of how other countries** have successfully integrated E-Sports into formal sport structures or governance frameworks.
6. **To propose pragmatic, institutionally coherent pathways for Belgium to engage with E-Sports**, aligning with Olympic values and preparing for future developments.

1.3. Methodology

This work combines desk research with primary qualitative data collection, integrating both global and Belgian perspectives:

- **Review of academic literature**: the list of references used for this work is provided at the end of the document.
- **Comparative analysis** of international case studies (e.g. South Korea, Finland, Sweden, France).
- **Stakeholder interviews** with Matthias Van Baelen, Director of Marketing, Communication and External Affairs at the BOIC, and Matthew Watson, performance coach and PhD researcher in E-Sports coaching at the Vrije Universiteit Brussel (VUB).

1.4. Structure of the report

This report is organised into **two main parts**.

The first part, ***Understanding E-Sports and its inclusion in the Olympic movement***, lays conceptual and institutional foundations by exploring how definitions of "sports" have evolved in the digital era and how E-Sports challenge traditional criteria such as physicality, competition, and institutional governance. It then analyses the IOC's current stance, including the implications of the IOC–Saudi partnership and the exclusion of popular non-sport titles, before suggesting ways the Olympic movement could adopt a more inclusive approach to digital competition. The second part, ***How should Belgium prepare itself for the future of E-Sports?*** focuses on the national context and outlines the main characteristics of the Belgian E-Sports ecosystem. It also presents international examples of countries that have integrated E-Sports in sports policy frameworks. The report concludes with strategic recommendations on the embedment of sport-simulation titles in traditional sports federations as a first step to formally include E-Sports within the Belgian Olympic movement.

Part I – Understanding E-Sports and its inclusion in the Olympic movement

2. Defining "Sport" in the digital era

2.1. Historical and theoretical perspectives on "Sport"

The concept of "sport" has evolved significantly over time. In its earliest sense, the term referred broadly to leisure or play, before acquiring a more modern meaning associated with organised physical competition.

Sociologists such as Allen Guttman and Norbert Elias have described sport as a social construct reflecting cultural, economic, and technological realities[4]. Historically, industrialisation and urbanisation were key to transforming spontaneous games into official sports, characterised by written rules, institutions, and mass spectatorship. The most commonly accepted definitions combine four core elements: **competition, rules, skill, and physicality**. Yet, the inclusion of motor sports, chess, and other non-Olympic sports shows the flexibility of this definition, suggesting that "physicality" can extend beyond gross motor activity to encompass **coordination, reflexes, and strategic decision-making** – all important skills to master in E-Sports[5].

E-Sports are best defined as **an electronic sports form** that demands high-speed visual and reactions time during all games. While traditional sports like football offer refined motor skills, control and balance, as well as strength, **E-Sports performance involves** fine-motor coordination, reaction speed, sustained attention, and cognitive endurance, **all measurable physiological capacities**[6].

While the **debate over the physicality and legitimacy of E-Sports** as a form of sport however remains strong, recent studies indicate that electronic sports can provide distinct cognitive benefits and may have positive effects in young population[7]. E-Sports are also safer and more accessible to the population than traditional sports, yet they still effectively teach the importance of competition, collaboration, and strategy. Looking at the Olympic landscape, these findings could align E-Sports with precision-based disciplines such as archery or shooting, where motor skill and focus outweigh physical endurance or strength. Consequently, the question is not whether E-Sports are "physical enough", but whether **our understanding of physicality must expand to accommodate digital forms of embodied performance**.

---

[4] Guttman Allen, *From Ritual to Record: the Nature of Modern Sports*, 1978, & ELIAS Norbert, *Quest for Excitement: Sport and Leisure in the Civilising Process*, 1986

[5] Van Hilvoorde Ivo & Pot Niek, *Embodiment and fundamental motor skills in E-Sports*, 2016

[6] Banyai Fanni, D. Griffiths Mark, Kiraly Orsolya, & Demetrovics Zsolt, *The Psychology of E-Sports: a Systematic Literature Review,* 2019

[7] Aybuke Ersin & Al., *The relationship between reaction time and gaming time in E-Sports players*, 2022, accessible here.

2.2. The Olympic definition and core criteria

The Olympic movement has long served as a global reference point for defining sport. While the IOC Charter[8] does not explicitly define "sport", it describes Olympism as a philosophy that integrates the "qualities of body, will, and mind" and promotes excellence, ethical conduct, and respect[9].

In practice, the Olympic model emphasises three interrelated dimensions:

1. **Physical dimension**: the presence of measurable bodily activity or motor skill.
2. **Institutional dimension**: the existence of structured governance under recognised federations.
3. **Ethical dimension**: adherence to values of fair play, non-violence, inclusion, and respect.

This being said, this framework has allowed for considerable evolution: once-contested disciplines such as surfing or skateboarding now feature on the Olympic programme, while other activities like chess, bridge, or Formula 1, remain outside despite their recognised competitive depth. This tension illustrates that **the definition of sport is ultimately negotiated, and not absolute.**

History has also shown that technology has always been shaping the evolution of the sporting industry and ecosystem. The inclusion of motor racing, sailing, or shooting in sporting institutions demonstrates that technological interfaces do not negate athletic legitimacy but redefine it. In E-Sports, **the field of play is virtual, but the contest remains human**, involving a battle of reflex, cognition, and coordination. The emergence of **mixed-reality sports** such as virtual cycling, rowing, or sailing during the *Olympic E-Sports Series* in 2023 further blurred the distinctions between physical and digital performance, suggesting more similarities than differences.

E-Sports therefore invites the Olympic movement to reconsider its conceptual boundaries. Rather than opposing "real" and "virtual" sport, the challenge lies in understanding **how digital competition can extend Olympism into new cultural and technological domains**.

[8] International Olympic Committee, *Olympic Charter*, 2025, accessible here.
[9] International Olympic Committee, *What is Olympism*, accessible here.



Figure 1 – Pictures from the 2023 Olympic E-Sports Series (IOC, 2023)

3. E-Sports and the question of legitimacy

3.1. Public perception: from "Gaming" to "E-Sports" to "Sport"

Public perception remains one of the primary barriers to differentiating E-Sports from gaming. For many, video games are still associated with leisure, entertainment, or even addictive behaviour, not structured competition. This perception is reinforced by decades of media narratives portraying gaming as a passive, solitary, or unhealthy activity.

In an interview given to France Inter in 2022[10], Kamel Kebir (alias Kameto) – a prominent French E-Sports entrepreneur, streamer, and co-founder of the E-Sports organisation *Karmine Corp* – acknowledged that **E-Sports in France still suffers from an oversimplified public perception**, often reduced to the image of individual merely playing behind a screen. He however emphasised that this situation reflects more from misunderstanding than genuine contempt, stemming from limited awareness of the professional, collective, and highly structure nature of competitive E-Sports. Kameto also mentioned his optimism in seeing this perception evolving over time, as younger generations, already deeply connected to E-Sports culture, progressively reshape cultural norms and expectations surrounding competitive gaming.

This gradual shift has indeed been observed in recent years. Major E-Sports events (Figure 3) have begun to be covered by mainstream broadcasters, global viewership have consistently grown over the past years (Figure 2)[11], and professional players are increasingly recognised as athletes within their communities. **E-Sports also resonates as a discipline that implies structure, professionalism, and competition**, while "gaming" evokes more casual play (Annex 1 – E-Sports vs Gaming).

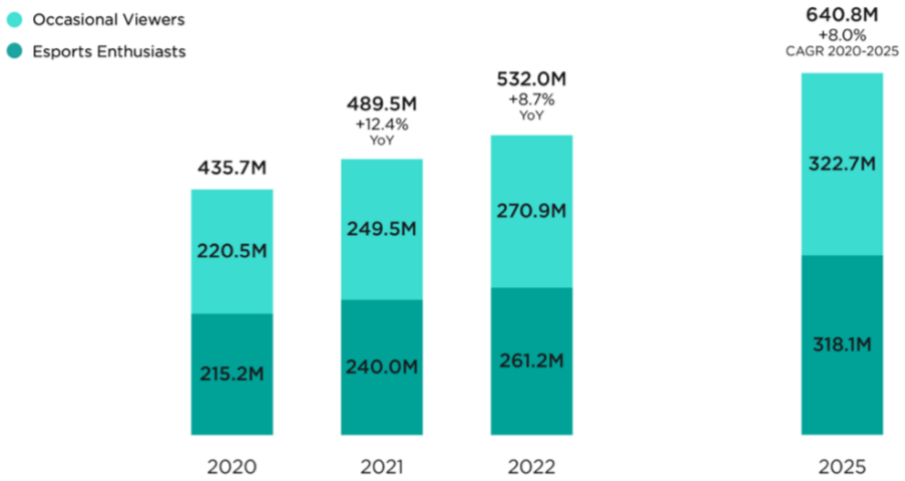


Figure 2 – E-Sports audience growth since 2020 and 2025 projections (Newzoo, 2022)

[10] France Inter, *Il y a encore du mépris envers l'E-Sports, mais c'est plus de l'incompréhension*, 14 September 2023, from minute 6 :03, accessible here.

[11] Newzoo, *The E-Sports audience will pass half a billion in 2022 in revenues, engagement, and new segments flourish*, 2022, accessible here.



Figure 3 – The 2024 League of Legends Worlds Final took place at the O2 Arena in London (Riot Games, 2024)

3.2. The professionalisation of E-Sports

Global Ecosystems

Despite public hesitation, the professionalisation of E-Sports is indisputable. Modern E-Sports ecosystems now include franchised leagues with multimillion-euro buy ins, transfer markets, talent academies, and hundreds of teams and organisations. For example, ***League of Legends***, one of the world's most popular Multiplayer Online Battle Arena (MOBA) games, was represented in 2024 by a total of **95 major organisations from 10 ecosystems of national or continental leagues**, with the European, Middle East, and African (EMEA) ecosystem including itself 110 pro-teams across 13 regions (Annex 2 – Overview of the *League of Legends* ecosystem worldwide in 2024).

Growing revenues and global audiences

The economic scale of E-Sports' ecosystem reinforces its legitimacy. Global E-Sports revenues (including media rights, sponsorship, and events) from recent years have been promising and seem to have surpassed the momentum gained during the COVID-19 pandemic[12], with E**-Sports' viewership having been on a steady upward trajectory** since 2022 (Figure 4). The E-Sports market is also **projected to reach 4.8 billion dollars in 2025** (Figure 5), with an expected compound annual growth rate from 2025 to 2030 of 5.35 %[13].



Figure 4 – Global E-Sports Viewership Dynamics (E-Sports Charts, 2024)

This rise can be attributed to several factors, including a **broader E-Sports circuit calendar**, **increased coverage** of top-tier E-Sports such as *League of Legends, Counter-Strike,* and *Dota 2*, **and the normalisation of co-streaming**, which expanded significantly in 2024[14].

[12] Deloitte Sports Business Group, *Let's Play! The E-Sports Market*, 2024, accessible here.
[13] Statista, *E-Sports market overview, last updated in 2025*, accessible here.
[14] E-Sports Charts, *E-Sports viewership is growing, what does it actually mean?*, 2023, accessible here.

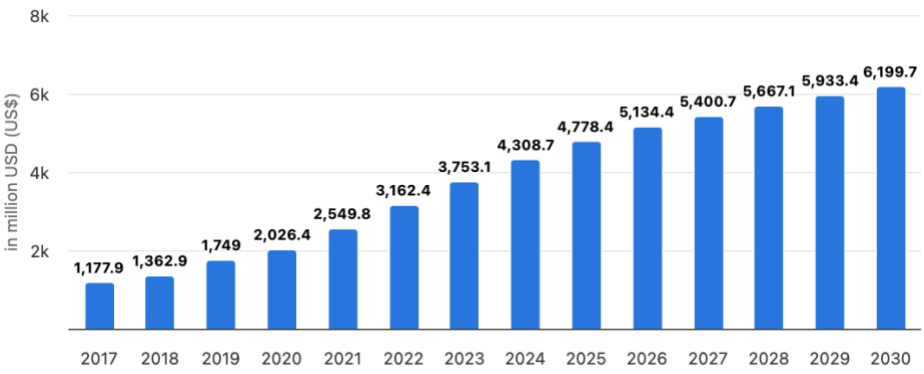


Figure 5 – E-Sports revenue market and 2025 – 2030 projections (Statista, 2025)

Media and broadcasting channels

Media discourse plays a crucial role in shaping how E-Sports are understood. Research identifies persistent problem-focused narratives (especially in traditional media), portraying gaming as addictive, unhealthy, or socially isolating[15]. Generalist online media typically adopt more neutral perspectives, framing E-Sports as a cultural or economic phenomenon. In contrast, younger digital-native outlets and sports journalism increasingly use **sportification narratives, emphasising competition, teamwork, and performance.**

As noted, global E-Sports viewership has continued to grow steadily over the past few years. As the audience expands, it is also becoming more segmented across different livestreaming platforms. ***Twitch*** remains a primary destination for PC gaming content, while ***YouTube Gaming*** has established itself as a key platform for mobile E-Sports titles[16]. The figure below highlights this trend: the top five most-watched E-Sports games on *Twitch* accumulated over 300 million hours watched in the first quarter of 2025 alone.



Figure 6 – Most watched E-Sports Games on Twitch during Q1 2025 (E-Sports Charts, 2025)

[15] Taylor T.L, *Play between worlds: media narratives of E-Sports*, 2018

[16] E-Sports Charts, *Counter-Strike becomes the most watched E-Sports game on Twitch in Q1 2025*, 2025, accessible here.

YouTube Gaming also showed considerable figures, with nearly 200 million hours watched for its top five games during the same period.



Figure 7 – Most watched E-Sports Games on YouTube Gaming during Q1 2025 (E-Sports Charts, 2025)

The rise of the E-Sports ecosystem has also led to a significant evolution in overall media coverage, leading to the **creation of dedicated talk shows and commentary outlets**, particularly on YouTube. Moving beyond simple games' broadcasting and highlights, channels have emerged to provide the narrative, analysis, and personality-driven content that mirrors traditional sports media.

In France, one of E-Sports most developed market in Europe, content creators like Zack Nani (with his "Zack en Roue Libre" format), Arthur Perticoz (ex-CEO of *Karmine Corp* and who recently launched a podcast on the backstage of E-Sports), or Paul Arrivé (journalist at *L'Équipe* who is often involved in in-depth gaming and culture discussions), have successfully bridged the gap between pure gameplay and cultural commentary.



Figure 8 – Examples of popular French E-Sports talk shows (Zack en Roue Libre, Stonks, La Boulange, OTP LoL Gaming)

This trend extends to public service broadcasting, with ***RTBF iXPÉ*** serving as a notable Belgian example (Annex 3 – *RTBF iXPé*). Launched in 2021, *RTBF iXPÉ* is a transversal media hub dedicated to gaming, E-Sports, and geek culture across platforms like *YouTube Gaming* and *Twitch*.

Such outlets leverage *YouTube's* format flexibility, allowing for long-format interviews, nuanced opinion segments, and retrospective discussions; all of this to cultivate a deeper sense of community and provide contextual storytelling that explains the payer narratives, organisational drama, strategic shifts within E-Sports, etc. and thereby fostering a highly engaged and loyal viewership.

Training and performance coaching

The image of gamers as sedentary or undisciplined clashes sharply with the reality of professional E-Sports athletes. Research highlights that **top competitors require exceptional cognitive abilities, fine motor skills, and rapid decision-making capacities**[17].

Training in leading European organisations can reach 8 to 12 hours per day, combining mechanical drills, strategic preparation, physical conditioning, and mental training. Organisations such as *Team Vitality*, *G2*, or *Karmine Corp* in Europe have facilities comparable to traditional sports clubs, and performance science research is rapidly expanding.

In a video presenting *Team Vitality's* and facilities, Alexander Spelda, Head Manager of the organisation in 2022[18], offered relevant insights showcasing the daily life of E-Sports athletes. He explained that players are required to be at the facilities six to seven days a week, including weekends, with team practice sessions running consistently from 12:00 PM to 8:00 PM.

A significant contrast exists in the training intensity observed in E-Sports organisations from other major regions, particularly in Asia, where routines are often reported as even more intense and demanding. For example, in an interview during the *League of Legends Worlds Championships* of 2025[19], Coach Tabe, head coach of the Chinese organisation *Anyone's Legends (AL)*, described a highlight structured and rigorous training schedule. His players routinely engaged in team practice in distinct blocks of hours:

- **Block 1**: 2:00 PM to 5:00 PM.
- **Block 2**: 7:00 PM to 9:00 PM.
- **Block 3**: 10:00 PM to 12:00 AM.

These team sessions are then followed by an extensive period of three to four hours of individual mechanical skill training, which typically lasts from midnight until 3:00 AM or

[17] PEDRAZA-RAMIREA Ismael & Al., *The Psychology of E-Sports: trends, challenges, and future directions*, 2025, accessible here.
[18] MGG France, *Voyage à Berlin chez Vitality*, 1 April 2022, accessible here.
[19] Caedrel Clips, *Caedrel asks Tabe about AL Team set-up and advice for EU*, 8 July 2025, accessible here.

4:00 AM. This comparison highlights a notable difference in the duration and structure of training commitment between major E-Sports regions.

Such intense training routines also come at a cost, with E-Sports facing **well-being issues** familiar to traditional high-performance sport: burnout, musculoskeletal injuries, sleep disturbances, short competitive careers, and inconsistent athlete support structures[20]. These challenges underline the need for clearer governance frameworks and welfare standards within the industry.

In response to the growing intensity of training and the associated well-being challenges, an increasing number of E-Sports organisations have begun to integrate **performance coaches** in their support staff. This role, which has gained significant visibility in recent years, draws on principles from sport science and performance psychology while being adapted to the specific demands of the E-Sports environment.

According to Matthew Watson, performance coach and PhD researcher in E-Sports coaching at the VUB and interviewed for this final work, **performance coaching extends beyond individual skill optimisation** to include team cohesion, communication dynamics, and social connection within a group of E-Sports players. Performance coaches are often involved in observing scrimmages (i.e. friendly training and games against other E-Sports teams), analysing in-game communication, and supporting training routines that balance performance demands with player health.

However, despite growing presence, the scope of performance coaching in E-Sports remains insufficiently defined, understood, and unevenly implemented. The need for stronger evidence-based approaches persists, and efforts in scientific research need to continue to identify which performance factors, particularly those related to health and sustainability, are most critical. Improved empirical understand would, in turn, allow performance coaches to better inform organisations and contribute to more effective and responsible high-performance environments.

[20] L'Équipe, *Le Burn-Out, un fléau qui s'aggrave dans l'E-Sport* , 2024, accessible here.

4. The Olympic dilemma

4.1. The IOC approach to E-Sports

The IOC's engagement with E-Sports has evolved gradually and cautiously. While the IOC has acknowledged the cultural and societal relevance of digital competition since 2017[21], its approach has remained deliberately narrow. Instead of embracing the full spectrum of E-Sports titles, the IOC has focused on formats that mirror existing Olympic sports, such as cycling, archery, tennis, motorsport, sailing, and taekwondo, through digital or virtual simulations.

Moreover, the IOC does not maintain a fixed, universal list of recognised sports. It rather **delegates recognition to International Federations (IFs)** that must demonstrate governance, integrity, and alignment with Olympic values[22].

In this context, E-Sports illustrates the IOC's cautious and evolving approach to emerging competitive practices. Despite the existence of international bodies such as the *International E-Sports Federation* (IESF) and the *Global E-Sports Federation* (GEF), **neither is formally recognised by the IOC as an International Federation** within the Olympic movement[23]. Rather than granting traditional federation recognition, the IOC has opted for a more direct and experimental engagement with E-Sports, organising dedicated initiatives such as the *Olympic E-Sports Series* and approving the creation *Olympic E-Sports Games*[24].

Figure 9 – Logos of E-Sports' two international federations (IESF & GEF)

This approach reflects ongoing concerns regarding governance fragmentation, publisher control over competition formats, and the alignment of certain game titles with Olympic values.

As a result, E-Sports currently occupies an **intermediate position**: acknowledged by the IOC as a significant global phenomenon with sporting potential yet not institutionalised within the conventional Olympic federation framework.

[21] International Olympic Committee, *E-Sports and Gaming Forum*, 2018, accessible here.
[22] International Olympic Committee, *What are the conditions required for a sport to be recognised by the IOC*, accessible here.
[23] The list of IFs recognised by the IOC can be found here.
[24] Full statement accessible here.

5. IOC-Saudi partnership: early termination and diverging strategies

As mentioned in the introduction of this report, the IOC announced in February 2025 that the **first edition of the Olympic E-Sports Games would take place in 2027, in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia**. Saudi Arabia hosting the inaugural Olympic E-Sports Games marked a major strategic shift: the country has invested heavily in E-Sports as part of its wider entertainment and international influence strategy, positioning itself as a global centre for major events and competitive gaming. According to PricewaterhouseCoopers's (PwC) latest report on E-sports trends[25], Saudi Arabia's investment in E-Sports and Gaming in 2022 was valued at more 38 billion dollars, supported by strong government investment, and a young and engaged audience.

For the IOC, such a partnership therefore promised financial security, rapid organisational capacity, but more importantly access to one of the fastest-growing E-Sports regions. However, **the partnership was short-lived** due to concerns within the Olympic movement regarding political implications, governance expectations, and the strategic direction of E-Sports development. The early termination of the agreement, announced in October 2025[26], exposed deeper divergences between a commercially expansive vision driven by state-led investment and rapid industry growth and the IOC's more caution, values-oriented strategy.

This episode reflects the clash of philosophies about how E-Sports should evolve and who should govern them on the world stage.

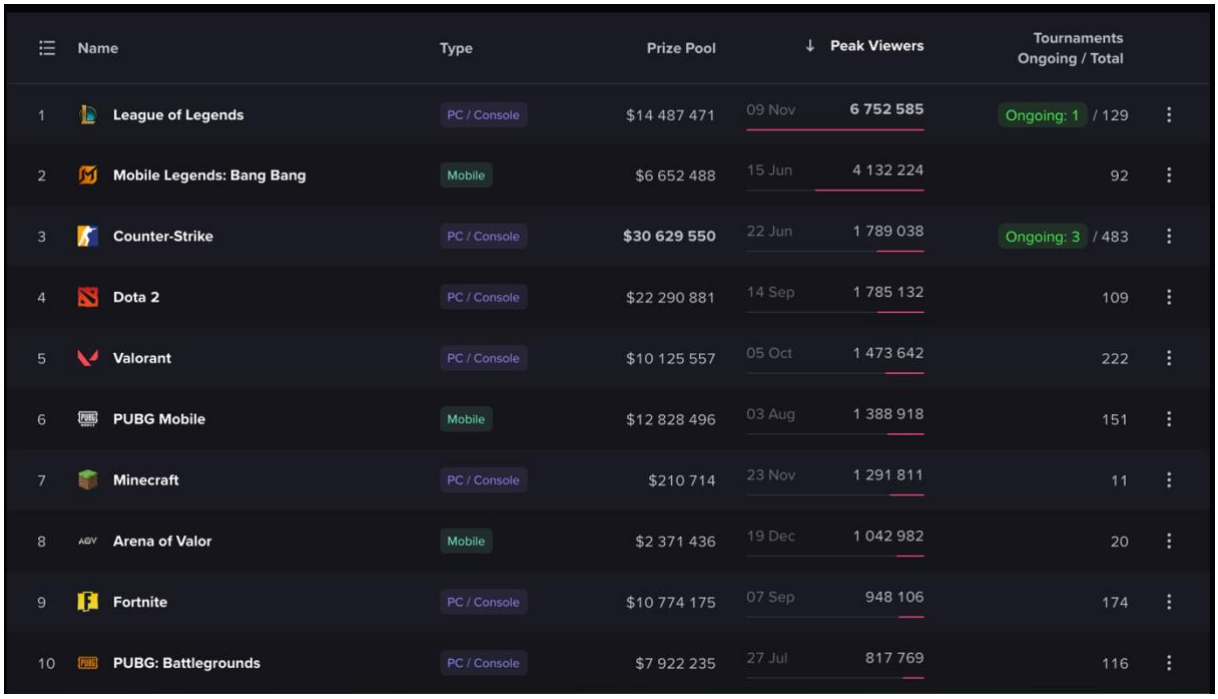
5.1. Sports simulations, non-sports simulations, and the paradox of exclusion: popular games being left out

Beyond questions of hosting and governance, another central debate shaping the IOC's engagement with E-Sports concerns the distinction between **sports-simulation games and non-sports simulation titles**. The IOC's preference for digital formats that replicate existing Olympic disciplines reflects long-standing concerns related to governance, values, and universality. Sports-simulation games can enable cooperation with established IFs, providing clear regulatory frameworks, recognised rules, and existing mechanisms for ethics, integrity, and safeguarding. From an institutional perspective, this approach would also allow the IOC to extend familiar governance models into the digital space without fundamentally altering the structure of the Olympic movement.

However, this strategy also exposes a fundamental tension. While E-Sports demonstrate exceptional audience reach, professionalisation, and competitive legitimacy, the titles that define E-Sports culture globally do not replicate physical sports and therefore fall outside the IOC's preferred framework. To illustrate this point, the figure below shows that

[25] The report can be accessible here.
[26] International Olympic Committee, *IOC Statement on the Olympic E-Sports Games*, 30 October 2025, accessible here.

the ten most-watched E-Sports titles in 2025 were predominantly non–sports simulation games, with well-established titles such as *League of Legends*, *Counter-Strike*, and *Dota 2* ranking among the most popular.



	Name	Type	Prize Pool	Peak Viewers		Tournaments Ongoing / Total
1	League of Legends	PC / Console	$14 487 471	09 Nov	6 752 585	Ongoing: 1 / 129
2	Mobile Legends: Bang Bang	Mobile	$6 652 488	15 Jun	4 132 224	92
3	Counter-Strike	PC / Console	**$30 629 550**	22 Jun	1 789 038	Ongoing: 3 / 483
4	Dota 2	PC / Console	$22 290 881	14 Sep	1 785 132	109
5	Valorant	PC / Console	$10 125 557	05 Oct	1 473 642	222
6	PUBG Mobile	Mobile	$12 828 496	03 Aug	1 388 918	151
7	Minecraft	PC / Console	$210 714	23 Nov	1 291 811	11
8	Arena of Valor	Mobile	$2 371 436	19 Dec	1 042 982	20
9	Fortnite	PC / Console	$10 774 175	07 Sep	948 106	174
10	PUBG: Battlegrounds	PC / Console	$7 922 235	27 Jul	817 769	116

Figure 10 – Popular E-Sports games in 2025 by viewership (E-Sports Charts, 2025)

The result is a **dual-track engagement**: E-Sports are acknowledged as a socially and culturally significant phenomenon, yet only partially integrated into the Olympic system. As presented before, this selective logic has directly shaped IOC initiatives such as the *Olympic Virtual Series*, the *Olympic E-Sports Week*, and the design of upcoming *Olympic E-Sports Games*.

The reluctance to include non-simulation titles is driven by a set of structural and ethical considerations. Many **mainstream E-Sports games raise concerns regarding alignment with Olympic values**, particularly when competitive mechanics involve representations of violence or conflict. Governance presents an additional challenge, as E-Sports ecosystems are controlled by private publishers who own the intellectual property, define competitive formats, and regulate disciplinary systems – contrasting sharply with the Olympic model based on independent, democratically governed IFs. Issues of integrity, athlete protection, and safeguarding are further complicated by fragmented regulatory environments, while universality is limited by regional publishing rights, server infrastructures and commercial market logics.

Taken together, these factors suggest that the IOC's hesitation is not purely normative, but deeply structural: **integrating non-sports simulation E-Sports titles would require a reconfiguration of governance principles** and institutional relationships at the core of the Olympic system.

Part II – How should Belgium prepare itself for the future of E-Sports?

6. The Belgian E-Sports ecosystem

6.1. Key stakeholders and institutional framework

Belgium's E-Sports landscape is young and still in a structurally fragile phase[27]. While actors such as the BESF, local tournament organisers, semi-professional teams, and university associations are increasingly active, **the ecosystem still lacks a coherent institutional framework**. This fragmentation is partly a result of the country's complex governance environment, where sport policy is managed separately by regional authorities (i.e. ADEPS, Sport Vlaanderen) and coordination across these bodies is essential for formal recognition and sustainable development.



Figure 11 – Logos of the BESF, Adeps, and Sport Vlaanderen

More importantly, **E-Sports is not yet formally recognised as a sport by the main public sport institutions of Belgium**[28]. Neither Sport Vlaanderen (Flemish Region) and ADEPS (Fédération Wallonie-Bruxelles) currently list E-Sports among their recognised sport disciplines, and there is no unified policy integration E-Sports into the official sport governance structure of either region. This absence of formal recognition means that E-Sports organisations cannot access the structural funding, athlete support programmes, or training infrastructures available to traditional sports. The regulatory and policy gap even extends to technical areas such as competition licence frameworks and athlete welfare support, which remain underdeveloped compared to established sports systems.

As a result, **E-Sports is often treated outside traditional sport policy**. In Flanders, for instance, official policy documents have emphasised that E-Sports is not integrated within the sport sector, viewing it instead as a distinct cultural or digital activity rather than part of the physical sport domain. This categorisation complicates access to sport-

[27] RTBF IXPé, *Pourquoi l'E-Sports peine-t-il à se professionnaliser en Belgique ?*, 2025, accessible here.
[28] E-Sports Insider, *E-Sports around the World: Belgium*, 2025, accessible here.

specific public programmes and support structures that are available to recognised federations and athletes within the traditional sport model[29].

Although **private actors**, such as gaming venues, sponsors, technology-related companies, and student associations, contribute to the vibrancy of the community, such kind of support tends to be project-based and not structurally embedded in the national sports ecosystem. For example, initiatives such as the planned E-Sports Campus of Oostkamp[30] – which brings together educational partners, Sport Vlaanderen, and industry actors to build a multi-use E-Sports space – illustrate the potential of cross-sector collaboration but also highlight how these efforts often arise outside formal sport policy channels.

From an **Olympic perspective**, this lack of formal recognition poses a specific challenge for the BOIC. The Committee's ability to engage with and recognise the BESF is constrained by the absence of a clear national policy stance on E-Sports within existing sport governance structures. Typically, **NOCs coordinate with public sport institutions and recognised federations** to establish athlete pathways, support services, and selection processes. In the case of E-Sports, however, these mechanisms are not fully established because the foundational step – **institutional recognition by bodies such as Sport Vlaanderen and Adeps – has not yet occurred**. This situation makes it difficult for the BOIC to position itself decisively on E-Sports, as great **alignment among regional sport policy actors is needed to create a coherent national framework** that can support both athlete development and international representation. Moreover, **granting the BESF membership to the BOIC in the absence of formal recognition by regional sport institutions would create governance inconsistencies** and raise questions regarding legitimacy, mandate, and parity with other recognised federations.

Addressing these recognition challenges would not only help E-Sports organisations and athlete locally but also provide the BOIC with a clearer mandate and pathway to engage with the discipline in line with Olympic values and international developments.

Private actors, including gaming venues, tech companies, and occasional brand sponsors, fill part of this void, but their involvement tends to be situational rather than long-term. The overall picture is therefore of a dynamic but under-structured ecosystem, where committed individuals and organisations are driving momentum despite limited public backing.

6.2. Market overview and growth trends

Belgium's E--Sports market remains **modest in scale but not marginal** when viewed in a European context. While it represents only a small share of the global E-Sports economy,

[29] Sport Vlaanderen, *E-Sports standupuntbepaling Vlaams sportbeleid*, 2023, accessible here.
[30] Belgian E-Sports Federation, *E-Sports Campus Oostkamp: a European first in Belgium!,* 2025,, accessible here.

Belgium ranked **19th worldwide in E-Sport revenues in 2022**, generating just over **10 million dollars**, which places it among the **top ten European countries** in absolute terms[31]. Despite this positioning, Belgium is generally characterised as a **developing rather than pioneering E-Sports market**. Deloitte's *Let's Play, Belgium! E-Sports & Gaming in Belgium 2022* report[32] highlights a growing yet still fragile ecosystem, marked by increasing awareness but comparatively lower engagement levels. In 2022, approximately **37 % of the Belgian population** reported being able to define E-Sports – a significant year-on-year increase, yet still below the European average of 41 %.

The audience profile nevertheless reveals strategic potential. The Belgian E-Sports public is predominantly male (64 %) and largely composed of **Millennials (25–41 years)** and **Generation Z (16–24 years)**, cohorts that are traditionally harder for institutional sport to reach. Notably, more than **half of Belgian E-Sports spectators also consume traditional sports**, a proportion significantly higher than in the general population, indicating that E-Sports does not exist in opposition to sport consumption but rather complements it.

The combination of moderate revenues, growing awareness, and relatively high cross-consumption with traditional sports reinforces the idea that E-Sports in Belgium has **untapped potential**, which remains difficult to unlock without clearer recognition, policy coordination, and long-term investment frameworks. This market context further explains why E-Sports development in Belgium continues to rely heavily on individual initiatives and private actors rather than benefiting from the systemic support mechanisms typically available to recognised sports disciplines.

[31] Statista, *E-Sports revenues per country, last updated in 2025*, accessible here.
[32] Accessible here.

7. The "sportification" of E-Sports internationally

Across the world, E-Sports in **increasingly intersecting with traditional sport governance structures**, including public authorities, national sports systems, and Olympic movements.

Several countries have taken **concrete steps** to formally recognised E-Sports as a sport, integrate E-Sports federations into national sports frameworks, or align E-Sports governance with National Olympic Committees (NOCs). The following use cases illustrate different models of recognition and integration, highlighting how E-Sports can coexist with, and complement, established institutions.

7.1. Use Case 1 – South Korea's formal recognition of E-Sports within its Olympic movement

South Korea represents one of the most advanced and mature examples of E-Sports integration within an Olympic movement framework. The Korea E-Sports Association (KeSPA), founded in 2000, serves as the official national governing body for E-Sports and has long been recognised by public authorities and sports institutions. Crucially, KeSPA is formally affiliated with the Korean Olympic Committee (KOC), placing E-Sports within the country's recognised Olympic sports ecosystem and categorised as a "second-level" Olympic sport alongside other recognised but non-medal disciplines.

Through this affiliation, **E-Sports in South Korea is treated as a recognised sporting discipline**[33] – often described as a "second-level" or non-Olympic sport – similar to how other recognised but non-Olympic activities are managed. This institutional recognition has enabled E-Sports to be included in major multi-sport events such as the *Asian Games*[34], where E-Sports has been contested as a medal event. South Korea's model demonstrates how E-Sports can be formally acknowledged within the Olympic movement without immediate inclusion in the Olympic Games themselves.

Building on this foundation, **the country has recently intensified discussions about hosting the *Olympic E-Sports Games*** following the collapse of partnership negotiations between the IOC and Saudi Arabia[35]. Hosting the event could represent an opportunity for the country to leverage on its expertise in gaming, technology, and E-Sports culture. Representatives from the KeSPA also highlighted the potential for successive editions to help standardise operational frameworks that could later be exported internationally. The future of the first *Olympic E-Sports Games* remains uncertain, but this recent interest shown by South Korea underscores the country's proactive approach to embed E-Sports within both national sport governance and the evolving Olympic agenda.

---

[33] Inquirer.NET, *E-Sports now recognised as a second-level Olympic sport, 2015*, accessible here.
[34] The full list of sports included in the upcoming 2026 Asian Games, in Japan, and including E-Sports, can be found here.
[35] E-Sports Insider, *Korean lawmakers push to host Olympic E-Sports Games*, 2025, accessible here.

7.2. Use Case 2 – Finland's E-Sports federation as member of the NOC

Finland provides a notable European example of direct integration between E-Sports governance and an NOC. The Finnish E-Sports Federation (SEUL) was accepted in December 2016 as an associate member of the Finnish NOC[36] and became a full member of the committee in 2019[37], making Finland one of the few countries where an E-Sports federation is formally embedded within the Olympic committee's membership structure.

This membership signifies that **E-Sports is recognised as part of Finland's organised sports system and Olympic movement**, even though E-Sports is not an Olympic sport. Through this framework, E-Sports benefits from alignment with national sports policies, good governance standards, and athlete-centred principles promoted by the Olympic movement. Finland's approach illustrates how NOC membership can serve as a pragmatic pathway for E-Sports legitimacy and institutional support at the national level.



Figure 12 – Logos of the Finnish Olympic Committee and E-Sports Federation (SEUL)

7.3. Use Case 3 – E-Sports recognised as a sport in Sweden

Sweden illustrates a model where E-Sports is formally recognised as a sport within the national sports system, even without direct membership in the National Olympic Committee. In June 2023, the **Swedish E-Sports Federation has achieved recognition through national sports structures**[38], allowing E-Sports to be treated comparably to other organised sports in terms of governance, development, and participation.

This recognition reflects Sweden's broader understanding of sport as an evolving concept that includes competitive digital activities. While E-Sports is not currently listed as a member federation of the Swedish Olympic Committee, its status as a recognised sport provides a strong foundation for public support, grassroots development, and alignment with national sports values. Sweden's case shows that formal sports recognition can exist independently of Olympic committee membership.

---

[36] International E-Sports Federation, *Finnish Olympic Committee accepts SEUL as Associate Member*, 2016, accessible here.
[37] International E-Sports Federation, *E-Sports now a full member of Finnish Olympic Committee*, 2019, accessible here.
[38] E-Sports Europe, *Sweden officially recognises E-Sports as a sport: Svenska E-Sportförbundet achieves historic milestone*, 2023, accessible here.

7.4. Use Case 4 – Numerous initiatives and legal recognition of E-Sports in France

France has adopted a distinct approach centred on legal recognition and structured public policy rather than formal Olympic committee membership. While E-Sports federations are not currently members of the French National Olympic and Sports Committee (CNOSF), France has put in place in 2016 a **clear legal framework for E-Sports competitions and professional players** that distinguishes E-Sports from gambling and informal gaming activities[39]:

- Professional players in France must be at least 12 years old to participate in competitions. Furthermore, underage players must have parental consent.
- Player compensation must comply with the legal minimum established by French law.
- Working hours are limited to a maximum of 35 hours per week, as stipulated by French law.

This legal recognition has helped professionalise the sector and ensure player protection and organisational standards.

In parallel, **France has launched multiple national initiatives to support E-Sports development**, involving ministries, public agencies, and representative bodies such as France E-Sports. A major first step was the holding of the E-Sports Assises in 2019, organised by the ministries responsible for Digital Economy and Sports. These meetings made it possible to initiate a deep reflection on the structuring of the French E-Sports ecosystem, with the aim of establishing a five-year roadmap. The roadmap, which underpins the national strategy "E-Sports Strategy for 2020–2025"[40], aims to make France the European leader in the sector by 2025, focusing on the following pillars:

1. Promoting the development of responsible and socially valued E-Sports practices.
2. Supporting the creation of a relevant training pathway, with a particular focus on elite players.
3. Implementing a policy to support the development of French E-Sports stakeholders.
4. Showcasing the attractiveness of France, its regions, and its E-Sports ecosystem to industry players and investors.

France's comprehensive legal and policy framework therefore demonstrates how strong state recognition can legitimise E-Sports alongside, rather than within, traditional Olympic structures.

---

[39] E-Sports Insider, *Développement de l'E-Sports en France: comment la scène e-Sportive s'impose!*, 2025, accessible here.
[40] French government, *Stratégie E-Sports 2020-2025*, last updated in 2024, accessible here.

8. Looking forward: E-Sports' inclusion within the Olympic movement

8.1. The future of the Olympic E-Sports Games

Despite the uncertainty surrounding the future of the Olympic E-Sports Games, the E-Sports industry continues to grow, and all indications suggest that **NOCs** will need to engage with E-Sports in the coming years. To what extent remains to be seen, but to ensure that NOCs are adequately prepared, the **IOC** will need to provide greater clarity—not only regarding its official stance on E-Sports but also on its vision for which types of titles and games should be included within the Olympic movement. From the IOC's perspective, the creation of *Olympic E-Sports Games* would require the organisation to carefully consider both the event format and the specific E-Sports titles to include.

Competitive E-Sports could be classified into the following categories:

- Sports simulations (virtual cycling, football, racing).
- Tactical and strategic games: Multiplayer Online Battle Arena (MOBA) and Real-Time Strategy (RTS) games.
- Precision and coordination games: First-Person Shooter (FPS).
- Emerging formats: Sandbox Strategy games or Virtual Reality (VR) games.

While a reimagined framework could adopt a fully inclusive approach across all categories, current IOC stances and organisational challenges suggest a more pragmatic path. For now, **it is more realistic for the IOC and the NOCs to limit the scope exclusively to sports simulation games**.

The **BOIC** has recently adopted a proactive approach towards their implication in E-Sports with the establishment of a dedicated Commission, officially launched in November 2025, composed of:

- Nathalie Clauwaert, member of the BOIC Board of Directors and General Director of Belgian Cycling.
- Patrick Van Campenhout, member of the BOIC Board of Directors.
- Samy Bessy, Vice-President of the BESF.
- Nicolas De Grove, E-Sports Counter-Strike 2 player.
- Luka Van Den Keybus, Olympian gymnast.
- Jaouad Achab, taekwondo Olympian.

The BOIC E-Sports Commission's mandate focuses on the monitoring of emerging trends and developments with the E-Sports industry, both in Belgium and internationally, also in view of any update that should be given in the coming weeks or months by the IOC on the *Olympic E-Sports Games*.

8.2. Embedding sports simulation titles within the scope of existing traditional sports federations

To integrate E-Sports into the Belgian Olympic movement, a viable solution could lie in a structural and organisational shift that is to **embed sports simulation titles directly in the scope of the activities of traditional sports federations**. Given that the Belgian E-Sports industry is still in its formative stages, it currently lacks the maturity and resources to sustain independent federations for every individual game license (or game types). By leveraging the established infrastructure of traditional federations, E-Sports can benefit from **decades of institutional expertise**, pre-existing regulatory processes, and recognised governance models.

International context

This model would align more closely with the Olympic movement's reliance on recognised International Federations and National Federations as the cornerstone of sport governance. At the **international level**, several IFs such as World Sailing, the Union Cycliste Internationale (UCI), World Taekwondo, and World Rowing, have developed official E-Sports formats that operate under their regulatory authority. These initiatives preserve a clear conceptual link between physical sport and digital competition, while ensuring alignment with Olympic values, integrity standards, and federation-based governance.

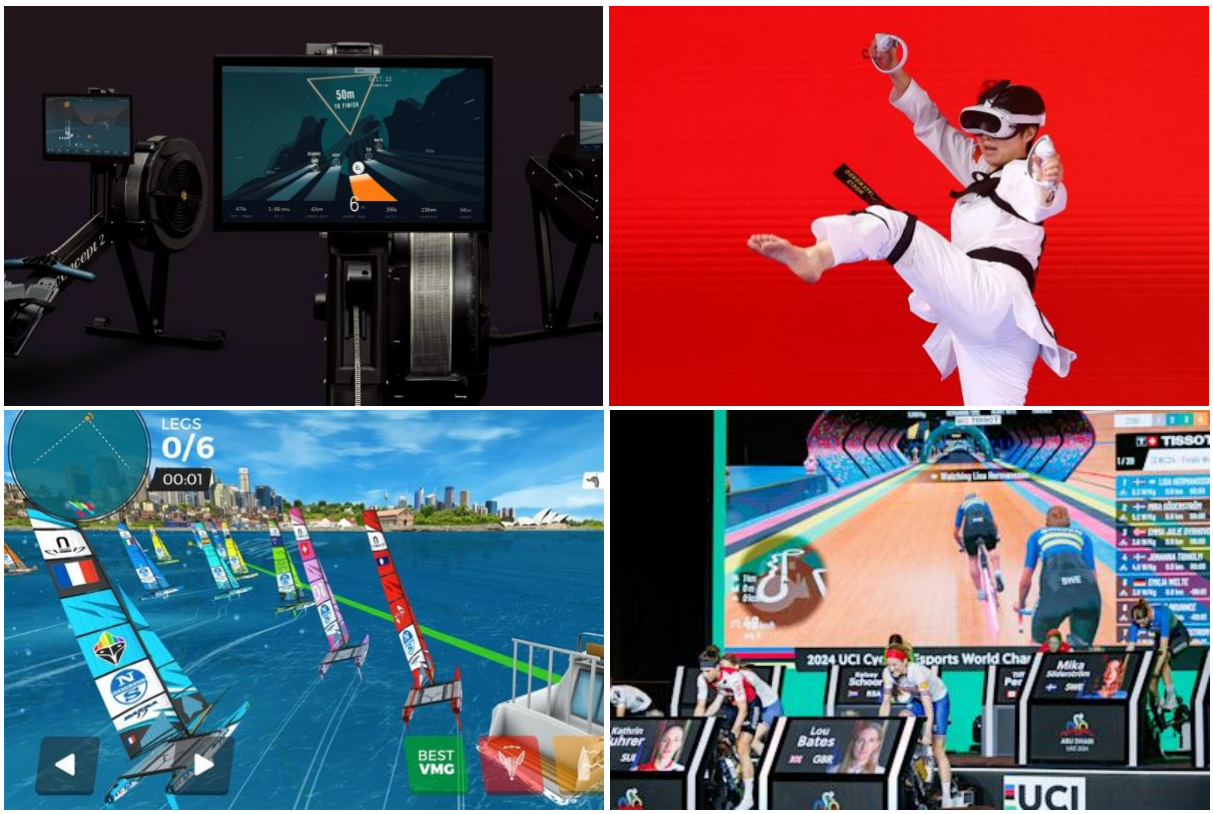


Figure 13 – Pictures from E-Sports initiatives organised by IFs in sailing, cycling, taekwondo, and rowing

Concrete examples of virtual competition (see additional examples in Annex 4) gaining traction alongside traditional sport can be found in disciplines such as rowing. Belgian

athlete **Ward Lemmelijn** has repeatedly won the *World Rowing Indoor Championships*[41], events that have included virtual racing formats and online participation, illustrating how digital competition can sit alongside established physical sport performance. Additionally, World Rowing continues to expand its virtual indoor championships, enabling competitors worldwide to engage in structured virtual racing under the governance of an established IF. In this configuration, virtual rowing does not replace the traditional discipline but rather complements it, expanding participation formats, visibility, and competitive opportunities — particularly for younger or digitally engaged audiences.

National context

From a governance perspective, such embedded model would also offer more clarity for institutions such as **Sport Vlaanderen, ADEPS**, and the **BOIC**. Rather than recognising E-Sports as a separate and contested sport category, **these bodies could integrate sports-simulation competitions as extensions of existing disciplines**, **governed by recognised federations** and subject to established regulatory frameworks. This approach would facilitate access to funding, athlete support services, and structured competition pathways without requiring a full redefinition of sport policy.

This model however also has limitations. While it offers a pragmatic solution for the integration of sport-simulation titles within the Olympic movement, **it does not resolve the broader question of how non-simulation E-Sports**, which dominate global viewership and professional ecosystems, **could eventually be accommodated within Olympic structures and competitions.** This **embedding strategy** should therefore be viewed as a **transitional mechanism rather than a comprehensive solution**: one that enables immediate institutional engagement with E-Sports while preserving flexibility for future governance innovations. Embedding sports-simulation E-Sports within traditional sports federations may indeed represent a more realistic short-to-medium-term strategy for Belgium, allowing the BOIC to engage with digital competition in a manner consistent with its governance principles, while avoiding premature institutional recognition of a fragmented E-Sport sector that has yet to achieve national policy consensus.

How could the BOIC support E-Sports moving forward?

From an operational perspective, the **BOIC's potential support to E-Sports athletes would need to remain consistent with its existing elite sport mandate and partnership with the three Communities** (Flemish, French, and German-speaking). The BOIC's core mission[42] is to support athletes and teams capable of achieving top-eight performances at World Championships and Olympic events, within clearly defined high-performance pathways. Should the BESF become a member federation of the BOIC, this would primarily grant access to institutional services rather than immediate financial

[41] World Sailing, *Ward Lemmelijn and his remarkable indoor rowing achievements*, 2024, accessible here.
[42] Belgian Olympic & Interfederal Committee, *Vision & Mission*, accessible here.

support. Such services could include legal and governance support, strategic guidance, international representation, and voting rights within the BOIC General Assembly. Direct financial subsidies, however, would likely be premature, as BOIC funding mechanisms are channelled through recognised federations that meet strict criteria related to governance, athlete pathways, and international competition structures.

This constraint further highlights the structural mismatch between existing Olympic funding models and the current organisation of E-Sports. In traditional sports, financial support flows from public authorities and the BOIC to federations, which then allocate resources to athletes integrated into national teams or officially recognised elite programmes. In E-Sports, such a structure is not yet clearly established, with athletes typically contracted directly by private teams rather than operating within a national federation framework. As a result, the **BOIC lacks a clear institutional interface through which to support E-Sports athletes in a manner consistent with its mandate**.

In this context, embedding sports-simulation E-Sports within traditional federations could represent a **first step for E-Sports athletes to be anchored within existing federation structures**, enabling the gradual creation of national team pathways, eligibility criteria, and performance benchmarks, and thereby **allowing BOIC's support to be extended in a structured, accountable, and values-aligned manner over time.**

8.3. Conceptual: classifying sport simulation titles eligible for federation embedding

A clear **classification framework identifying which virtual disciplines can legitimately fall under existing sport governance structures** could be a first step to explore the embedment of sport simulation titles within traditional sports federations. Not all E-Sports titles are suitable for such integration, and a structured assessment is required to distinguish sport-simulation formats that retain a meaningful link to physical sport from those that remain primarily game-driven.

Primary classification test, exclusion criteria and governance quality check

At its core, such a framework would assess whether a virtual activity genuinely simulates an existing sport recognised within Belgian and international sport governance, whether athletic performance is predominantly determined by physical effort rather than controlled-based input, and whether measurable and verifiable performance metrics allow for integrity, comparability, and transferability to traditional sport performance. In this sense, disciplines such as virtual cycling or indoor rowing clearly differed from conventional E-Sports titles, as they rely on sport-specific equipment, physiological output, and competition formats closely aligned with traditional cycling.

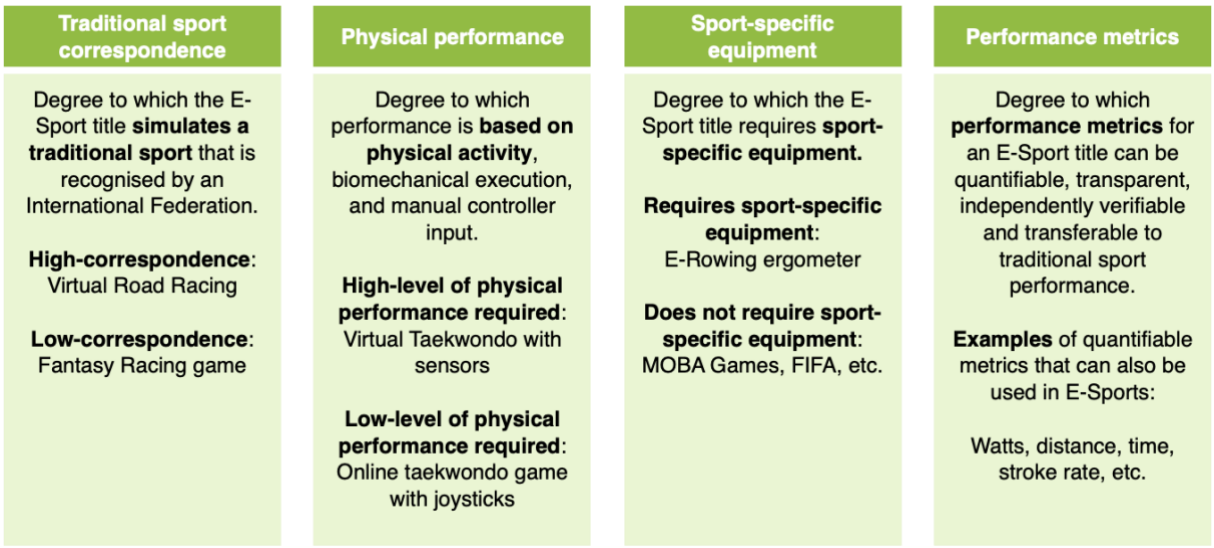


Figure 14 – Primary classification test criteria

In parallel, **explicit exclusion criteria** (Figure 15) should apply. Activities in which outcomes are driven primarily by gameplay mechanics, fictional concepts, or publisher-controlled competitive formats would be automatically excluded from federation embedding. This prevents the dilution of sport governance principles and preserves institutional coherence.

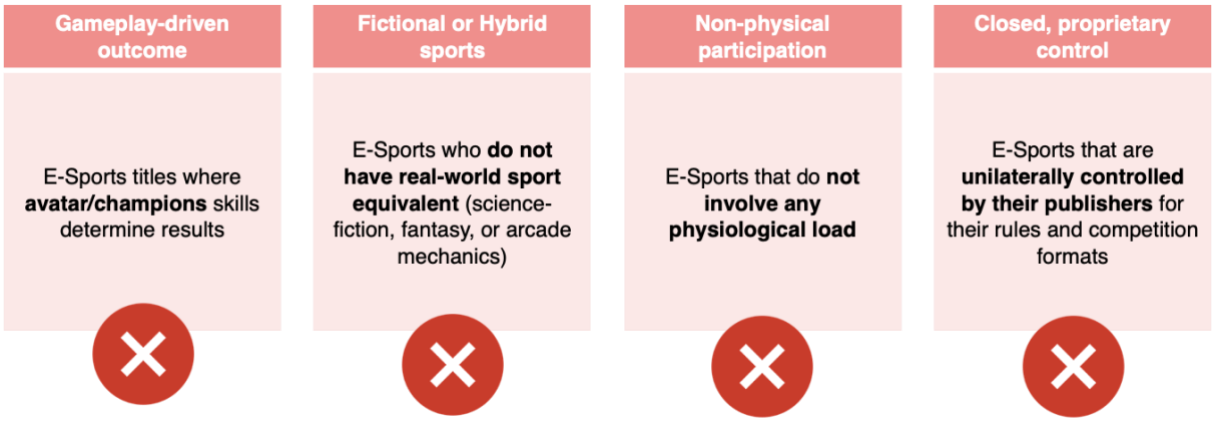


Figure 15 – Exclusion criteria

From a **governance perspective**, a secondary quality check (Figure 16) could also made to assess the alignment of the rules of a sport simulation title with the traditional sport, the role of technology (to ensure it has a role of mediation rather than substitution of athletic skill), and competition integrity mechanisms such as anti-cheating measures and equipment calibration standards.

Rule alignment	Role of technology	Competition integrity
High – the rules of the E-Sport title mirror traditional sport almost exactly Medium – small adaptations are required Low – The E-Sport title almost totally differs from the traditional sport	Acceptable: technology measures performance only, or it mediates the environment but not the ability required to perform Not acceptable: technology replaces athletic skill completely	The E-Sport title involves anti-cheating mechanisms, and equipment calibration standards are defined

Figure 16 – Governance quality check criteria

Together, these elements provide a solid basis for eligible titles to be governed in a manner consistent with existing sport federation practices.

Defining classification outcomes and mapping sports simulation titles

Beyond this initial eligibility assessment, a **final level of analysis** (Figure 17) could differentiate between simulation formats that are fully suitable for competitive integration within federations, those that may be used in more limited or development contexts (e.g. youth competitions), and those whose primary values lies in training, rehabilitation, or talent identification rather than standalone competition. Such a graduated approach would allow federations to engage with virtual formats without being forced into a binary choice between full recognition or exclusion.

A	B	C	D
Federation Discipline	**Federation Format Experiment**	**Training & Development**	**Excluded**
The E-Sport title is **fully integrated within a sport federation** and is eligible for national championships, federation licensing, and talent pathways **Example** Virtual Road Cycling (UCI)	The E-Sport title is **recognised by a sport federation but with a limited scope for competition**. This type of title is not mature yet and could be further tested in (for example) youth competitions **Example** Virtual Rowing	The E-Sport title does not have a standalone competitive status but is used for coaching, development, and rehabilitation purposes **Example** Virtual Reality Tennis, Virtual Reality Boxing drills	The E-Sport title is governed by E-Sport publishers and falls outside of the scope of a sport federation. **Example** FIFA, League of Legends, games played only with controllers, etc.

Figure 17 – Classification outcomes

Based on the results of the classification and governance assessment, sport simulation titles can be assigned to **differentiated outcomes**. Some activities may qualify as fully integrated federation disciplines, eligible for national championships, athlete licensing, and elite pathways. Others may be recognised as federation-sanctioned formats with

limited competitive scope, suitable for mass participation, youth development, or seasonal competition. A third category could include applications used exclusively as training or development tools without standalone competitive status. Activities that fail to meet the core criteria remain outside sport federation governance and fall under the remit of E-Sports bodies or publishers.

This tiered approach would help avoiding a binary inclusion–exclusion logic and allows federations to engage with virtual sport formats at varying levels of institutional commitment.

Once classification outcomes are defined, **eligible sport simulation titles can be mapped to their corresponding traditional sport federations**. This mapping follows the principle of sport specificity: virtual cycling to cycling federations, virtual rowing to rowing federations, and so forth. Such alignment reinforces existing governance structures, ensures technical expertise, and facilitates the integration of virtual athletes into established competition calendars, licensing systems, and performance pathways.

This step also provides clarity for athletes, technology providers, and event organisers by identifying the competent authority responsible for rules, competition approval, and disciplinary oversight.

Governance implications

The responsibility for conducting and overseeing this classification process would likely need to be shared. **Regional sport authorities** such as ADEPS and Sport Vlaanderen are well placed to assess alignment with existing sport governance frameworks and public policy objectives. **The BOIC could play a coordinating and strategic role**, ensuring coherence with Olympic principles and international federations' practices. **The BESF could also contribute with its technical expertise** on digital competition formats and act as an interface with the broader E-Sports ecosystem.

By clarifying which sport simulation titles can be embedded within traditional federations, this framework offers a pragmatic and institutionally compatible pathway for integrating E-Sports into the Belgian Olympic movement, while preserving governance integrity and leaving space for future evolution beyond sport simulations.

9. Conclusion

The objective of this work was to examine the **relationship between E-Sports and the Olympic movement**, with a particular focus on the implications for Belgium and the BOIC. Through an analysis of the definition of sport in the digital era, the professionalisation and legitimacy of E-Sports, and the cautious engagement of the IOC, the report aims to demonstrate that the question is no longer whether E-Sports constitute a meaningful form of competition, but rather how—and under which conditions—they can be integrated into existing sport governance frameworks.

The **Olympic movement's current approach reflects a fundamental tension**. On the one hand, the IOC recognises the cultural relevance, youth appeal, and global reach of E-Sports. On the other, it remains constrained by governance, ethical, and institutional considerations that limit its engagement to sports-simulation formats. The early termination of the IOC–Saudi partnership further illustrated the fragility of this balance, exposing divergent visions between commercially driven expansion and values-based governance.

At the national level, Belgium mirrors many of these challenges. Despite a growing audience, active stakeholders, and increasing professionalisation, **the Belgian E-Sports ecosystem remains fragmented and insufficiently embedded within formal sport policy**. The absence of recognition by regional sport authorities, combined with limited coordination across governance levels, restricts access to structural support and complicates the BOIC's ability to engage with E-Sports in line with its mandate. International case studies demonstrate that alternative pathways are possible. Whether through formal Olympic affiliation (South Korea, Finland), national sport recognition (Sweden), or legal and policy frameworks (France), **E-Sports can be integrated into public sport systems without undermining institutional integrity**. These examples underline that legitimacy is not binary but can be constructed through gradual, context-specific governance solutions.

In this perspective, emb**edding sport-simulation titles within existing traditional sports federations** could provide a pragmatic and institutionally coherent pathway for Belgium. While this approach does not resolve the broader question of non-simulation E-Sports, it enables immediate engagement with digital competition, preserves alignment with Olympic values, and creates space for future governance evolution. By adopting a clear classification framework, fostering coordination between regional authorities, federations, and the BESF, and positioning itself proactively within international discussions, the BOIC could play a constructive role in shaping the future of E-Sports within the Olympic movement.

Ultimately, **E-Sports should not be viewed as a threat to traditional sport**, but as an extension of competitive practice shaped by contemporary technological and cultural realities. The challenge for Olympic institutions is not to resist this evolution, **but to guide it responsibly**.

References

Books

- Aybuke Ersin & Al., *The relationship between reaction time and gaming time in E-Sports players*, 2022, accessible on : https://hrcak.srce.hr/file/397244
- Banyai Fanni, D. Griffiths Mark, Kiraly Orsolya, & Demetrovics Zsolt, *The Psychology of E-Sports: a Systematic Literature Review,* 2019
- Elias Norbert, *Quest for Excitement: Sport and Leisure in the Civilising Process*, 1986
- Guttman Allen, *From Ritual to Record: the Nature of Modern Sports*, 1978
- Taylor T.L, *Play between worlds: media narratives of E-Sports*, 2018
- Van Hilvoorde Ivo & Pot Niek, *Embodiment and fundamental motor skills in E-Sports*, 2016

Reports

- Deloitte Sports Business Group, *Let's Play! The E-Sports Market*, 2024, accessible on: https://www.deloitte.com/content/dam/assets-zone2/ch/en/docs/industries/technology-media-telecommunications/2024/deloitte-ch-the-swiss-esports-market-2024.pdf
- Deloitte Belgium, *Let's Play, Belgium! E-Sports & Gaming in Belgium*, 2022, accessible on: https://www.deloitte.com/content/dam/assets-zone2/be/en/docs/industries/tmt/2022/be-lets-play-report-2022.pdf
- French government, *Stratégie E-Sports 2020-2025*, last updated in 2024, accessible on: https://www.entreprises.gouv.fr/secteurs-dactivite/numerique/lesport/strategie-esport-2020-2025
- PricewaterhouseCoopers, *Game publishers, the cornerstone of E-Sports*, 2022, accessible on: https://www.pwc.com/m1/en/publications/2025/docs/game-publishers-the-cornerstone-of-esports.pdf
- Sport Vlaanderen, *E-Sports standupuntbepaling Vlaams sportbeleid*, 2023, accessible on: https://publicaties.vlaanderen.be/view-file/58746?utm

Academic journal articles

- Pedraza-Ramirea Ismael & Al., *The Psychology of E-Sports: trends, challenges, and future directions*, 2025, accessible on: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1469029225001669?via%3Dihub

Online videos

- Caedrel Clips, *Caedrel asks Tabe about AL Team set-up and advice for EU*, 8 July 2025, accessible on: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TXvGOQvjOew
- France Inter, *Il y a encore du mépris envers l'E-Sports, mais c'est plus de l'incompréhension*, 14 September 2023, from minute 6 :03, accessible on : https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wYgNEtdQZLE
- International Olympic Committee, *E-Sports and Gaming Forum*, 2018, accessible on: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=A50HV9q6oso&t=7746s
- MGG France, *Voyage à Berlin chez Vitality*, 1 April 2022, accessible on : https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TbC1d3Y-Lvg

Electronic sources

Institutional reports

- E-Sports Charts, *E-Sports viewership is growing, what does it actually mean?*, 2023, accessible on: https://escharts.com/news/esports-growing-what-does-it-really-mean
- E-Sports Charts, *Counter-Strike becomes the most watched E-Sports game on Twitch in Q1 2025*, 2025, accessible on: https://escharts.com/news/esports-games-twitch-youtube-q1-2025
- E-Sports Charts, *Popular E-Sports games by viewership in 2025*, 2025, accessible on: https://escharts.com/top-games?order=peak
- Statista, *E-Sports market overview, last updated in 2025*, accessible on: https://www.statista.com/outlook/amo/esports/worldwide?srsltid=AfmBOopPjGi2onAruQxTnUUyprsF_fx2GsRQR9mQ8KTScIuFuOpt6NuB

Online articles and references

- Belgian E-Sports Federation, *E-Sports Campus Oostkamp: a European first in Belgium!,* 2025, accessible on: https://www.besf.be/news/besf/esports-campus
- Belgian Olympic & Interfederal Committee, *Committees and Commissions*, accessible on: https://www.teambelgium.be/en/about-boic/committees-and-commissions
- Belgian Olympic & Interfederal Committee, *Vision & Mission*, accessible on: https://www.teambelgium.be/en/about-boic/vision-mission
- DifferenceBetween.NET, Differences between E-Sports and Gaming, 2022, accessible on: https://www.differencebetween.net/technology/difference-between-esports-and-gaming/
- E-Sports Europe, *Sweden officially recognises E-Sports as a sport: Svenska E-Sportförbundet achieves historic milestone*, 2023, accessible on:

https://eef.gg/sweden-officially-recognizes-esports-as-a-sport-svenska-e-sportforbundet-achieves-historic-milestone/

- E-Sports Insider, *Développement de l'E-Sports en France: comment la scène e-Sportive s'impose!*, 2025, accessible on: https://tinyurl.com/57v2nu33
- E-Sports Insider, *E-Sports around the World: Belgium*, 2025, accessible on: https://esportsinsider.com/2024/03/esports-around-the-world-belgium
- E-Sports Insider, *Korean lawmakers push to host Olympic E-Sports Games*, 2025, accessible on: https://esportsinsider.com/2025/12/korean-lawmakers-push-to-host-olympic-esports-games
- International E-Sports Federation, *Finnish Olympic Committee accepts SEUL as Associate Member*, 2016, accessible on: https://iesf.org/finnish-olympic-committee-accepts-seul-as-associate-member/
- International E-Sports Federation, *E-Sports now a full member of Finnish Olympic Committee*, 2019, accessible on: https://iesf.org/e-sports-now-a-full-member-of-finnish-olympic-committee/
- Inquirer.NET, *E-Sports now recognised as a second-level Olympic sport*, 2015, accessible on: https://esports.inquirer.net/4377/esports-now-recognized-as-2nd-level-olympic-sport
- International Olympic Committee, *IOC Statement on the Olympic E-Sports Games*, 30 October 2025, accessible on: https://www.olympics.com/ioc/news/ioc-statement-on-the-olympic-esports-games
- International Olympic Committee, *IOC announces Olympic E-Sports Games to be hosted in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia*, 12 July 2024, accessible on: https://www.olympics.com/ioc/news/ioc-announces-olympic-esports-games-to-be-hosted-in-the-kingdom-of-saudi-arabia
- International Olympic Committee, *List of International Federations*, accessible on: https://www.olympics.com/ioc/international-federations
- International Olympic Committee, *Olympic Charter*, 2025, accessible on : https://www.olympics.com/ioc/olympic-charter
- International Olympic Committee, *What is Olympism*, accessible on: https://www.olympics.com/ioc/faq/olympism-and-the-olympic-movement/what-is-olympism
- International Olympic Committee, *What are the conditions required for a sport to be recognised by the IOC*, accessible on: https://www.olympics.com/ioc/faq/sports-programme-and-results/what-are-the-conditions-required-for-a-sport-to-be-recognised-by-the-ioc

- L'Équipe, *Le Burn-Out, un fléau qui s' aggrave dans l'E-Sport*, 2024, accessible on: https://www.lequipe.fr/Esport/Article/Isolement-pression-precarite-de-plus-en-plus-de-gamers-pros-souffrent-de-burn-out/1517242
- Newzoo, *The E-Sports audience will pass half a billion in 2022 in revenues, engagement, and new segments flourish, 2022*, accessible on: https://newzoo.com/resources/blog/the-esports-audience-will-pass-half-a-billion-in-2022-as-revenue-engagement-esport-industry-growth
- RTBF IXPé, *Quelles perspectives d'avenir pour l'E-Sports en Belgique?*, 10 November 2025, accessible on: https://www.rtbf.be/article/quelles-perspectives-d-avenir-pour-l-esport-en-belgique-11628844
- RTBF IXPé, *Pourquoi l'E-Sports peine-t-il à se professionnaliser en Belgique ?*, 2025, accessible on : https://www.rtbf.be/article/pourquoi-l-esport-peine-t-il-a-se-professionnaliser-en-belgique-11621258
- Topend Sports, *Asian Games, 2025*, accessible on: https://www.topendsports.com/events/games/asian-games/sports/index.htm
- Union Cycliste Internationale, *2025 UCI Cycling E-Sports World Championships*, 2025, accessible on: https://www.uci.org/competition-hub/2025-uci-cycling-esports-world-championships/7yaBDFMwGaC5IMoH0tUAeh
- World Rowing, *World Rowing partners with Ergatta for Gaming and Esports development of its Indoor/Connected Rowing discipline*, 2025, accessible on: https://worldrowing.com/2025/10/06/world-rowing-partners-with-ergatta-for-gaming-and-esports-development-of-its-indoor-connected-rowing-discipline/
- World Sailing, *Ward Lemmelijn and his remarkable indoor rowing achievements*, 2024, accessible on: https://worldrowing.com/2024/02/11/ward-lemmelijn-and-his-remarkable-indoor-rowing-achievements/
- World Sailing, *World Sailing 2026 eSailing World Championship*, last updated in 2025, accessible on: https://www.sailing.org/esailing
- World Taekwondo, *Virtual Taekwondo*, last updated in 2025, accessible on: https://www.worldtaekwondo.org/virtualtaekwondo/contents

Annexes

Annex 1 – E-Sports vs Gaming

Esports vs **Gaming**

Comparison Table

Characteristics	Esports	Gaming
Definition	Refer to professional and competitive video gaming in the form of competitions played by professional gamers	Refers to the act of playing video games
Player characteristics	Takes the place of organized gaming competitions between teams or individual professional players with a large number of bystanders and audiences	Involves playing against non-player characteristics, commonly referred to as a bot
Live matches	Promotes live matches	Does not promote live matches

DB Difference Between.net

Figure 18 – E-Sports vs Gaming (DifferenceBetween.Net, 2021)

Annex 2 – Overview of the *League of Legends* ecosystem worldwide in 2024



Figure 19 – League of Legends worldwide ecosystem in 2024 (Tier 1)

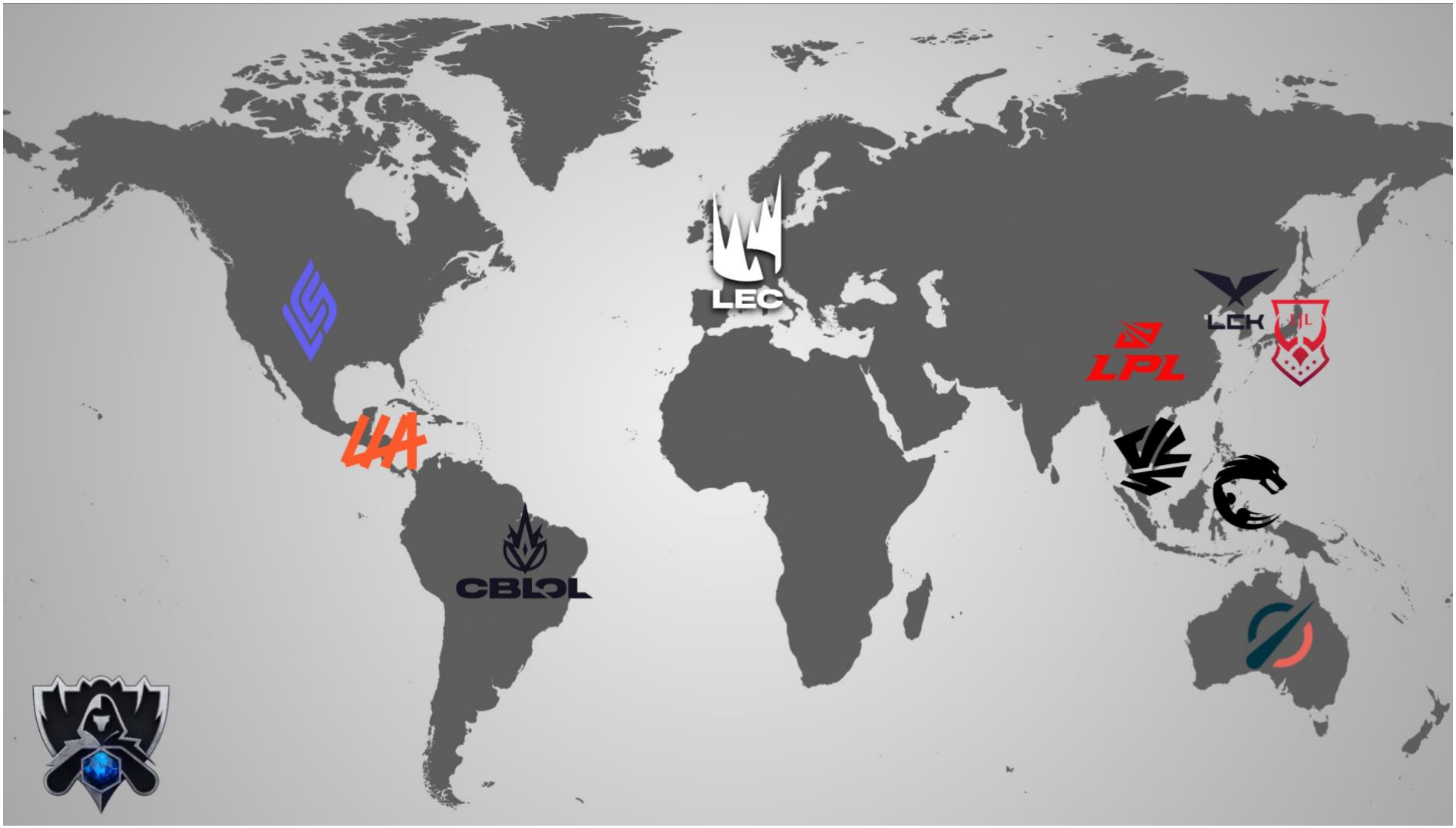


Figure 20 – League of Legends worldwide ecosystem representation (Tier 1)



Figure 21 – League of Legends European, Middle-East, and African (EMEA) ecosystem (Tier 2)



Figure 22 – League of Legends European, Middle-East, and African (EMEA) ecosystem representation (Tier 2)

Annex 3 – *RTBF iXPé*

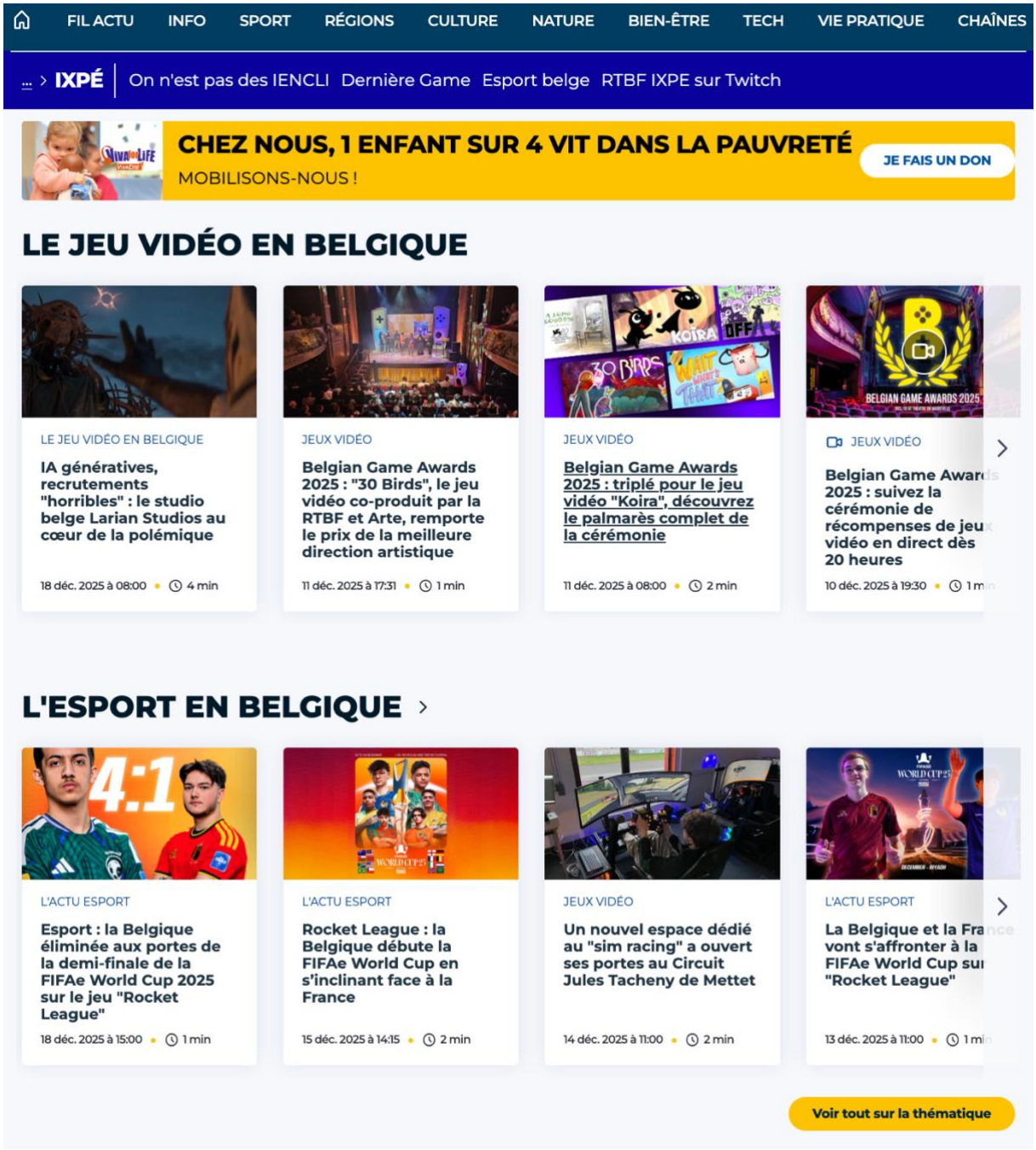


Figure 23 – RTBF iXPé homepage

Annex 4 – International Federations and E-Sports

World Sailing



In partnership with the leading digital sailing platform, Virtual Regatta, World Sailing continues its journey into the virtual realm with the 8th eSailing World Championship.

World Sailing 2026 eSailing World Championship

In partnership with the leading digital sailing platform, Virtual Regatta, World Sailing continues its journey into the virtual realm with the 9th eSailing World Championship. Since its launch in 2018, the Championship has evolved, bringing together Olympic sailors, sailing enthusiasts, sports gamers, and newcomers from across the globe.



Figure 24 – World Sailing announcement of 2026 eSailing World Championship

Union Cycliste Internationale (UCI)

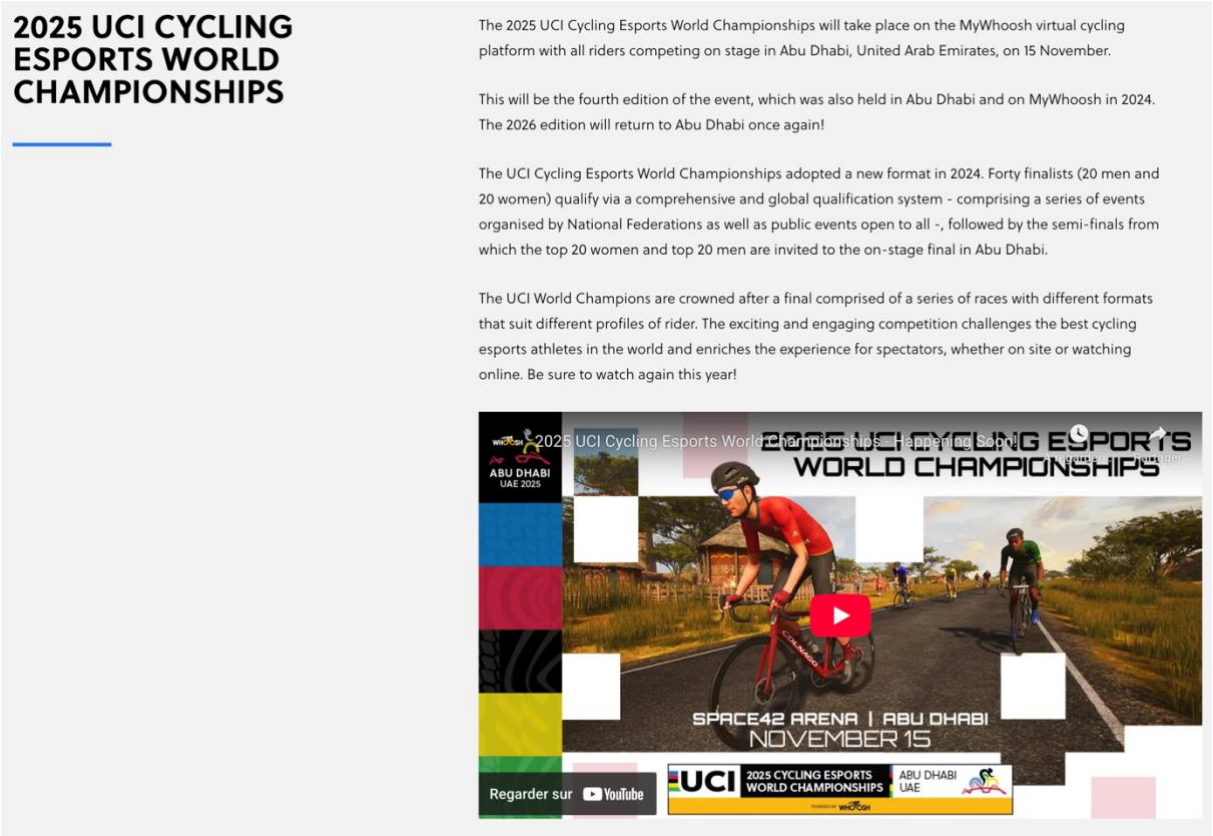


Figure 25 – Announcement of UCI's 2025 Cycling E-Sports World Championships

World Rowing

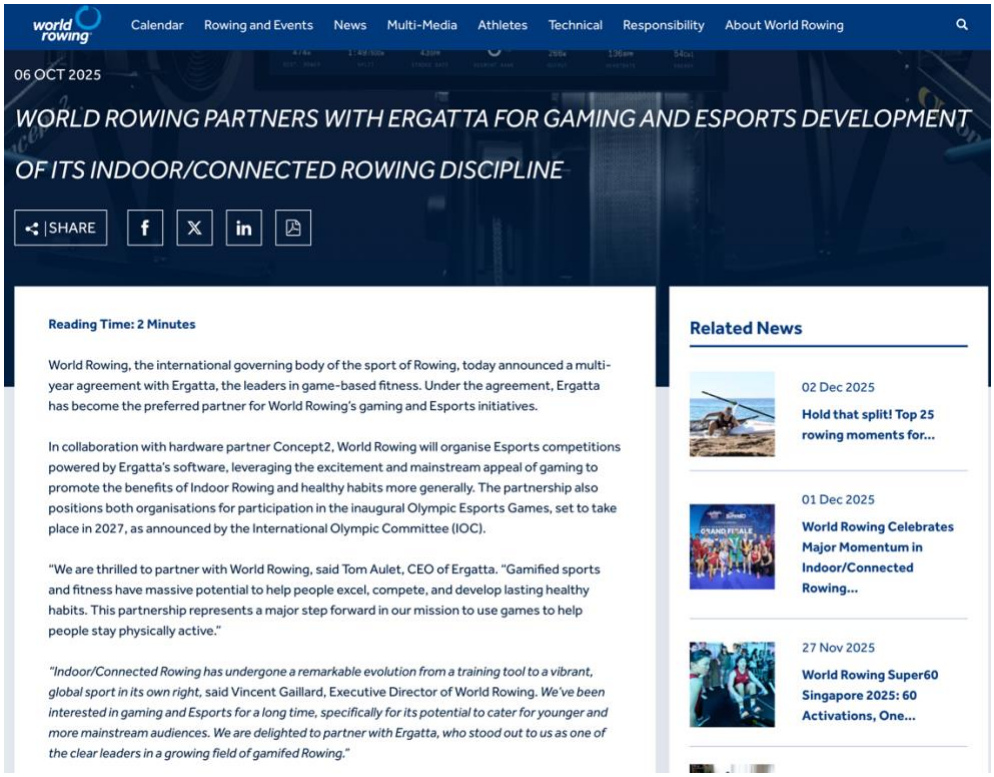


Figure 26 – World Rowing's partnership announceemnt with Ergatta for gaming and E-Sports development

World Taekwondo

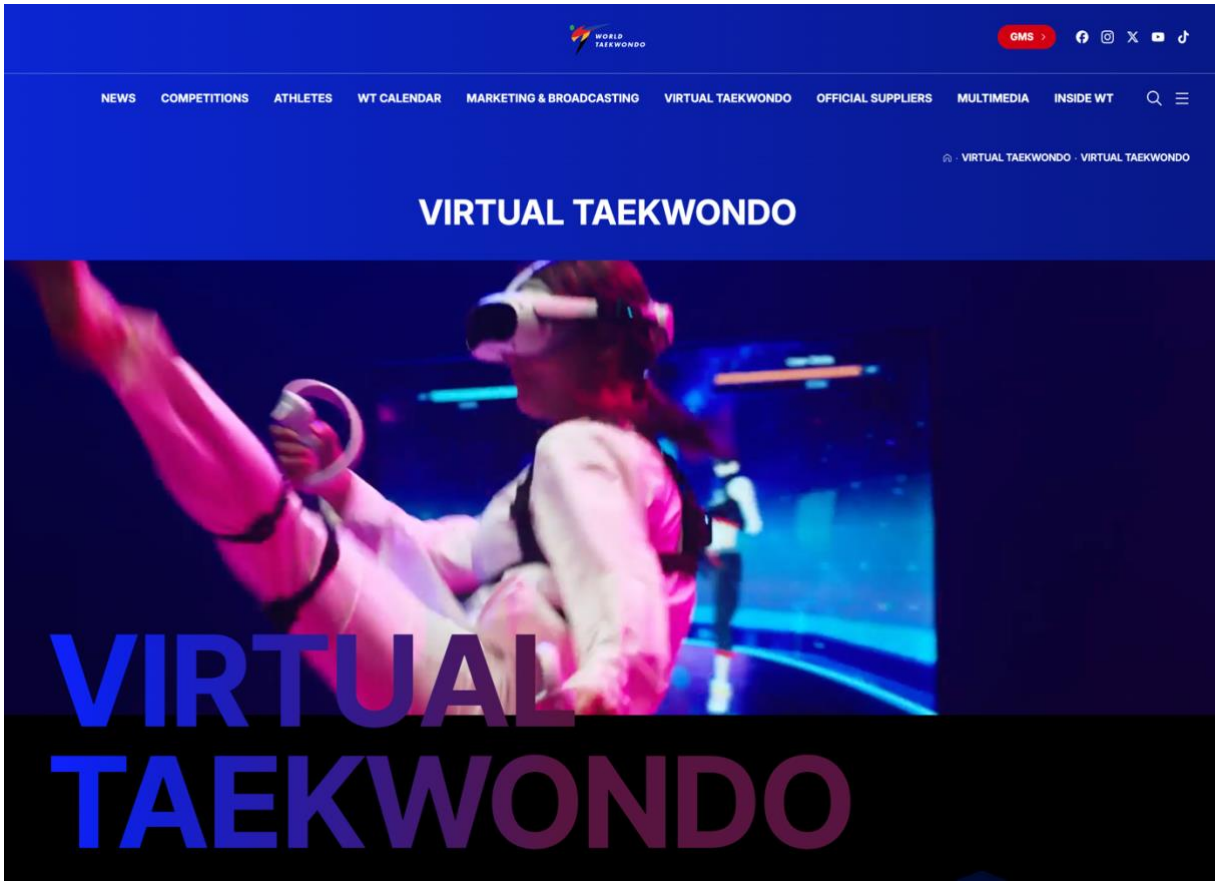


Figure 27 – Virtual Taekwondo has recently been officially endorsed by World Taekwondo